

LESSON 8

The Subjunctive Future: The Imperfect Tense

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 7

Quick Summary

In Lesson 7, we tackled “weak roots”—verbs that contain an Alaph (Ⲁ) or Yodh (ⲓ). We saw that while they can lose or transform their weak consonants in conjugation (e.g., ⲓ-*m-r* → ⲓ *emar*; ⲕ-*z-y* → ⲕ *hzā*), they still behave syntactically like normal verbs.

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. What does the Yodh in a III-Yodh verb turn into in the 3rd masc singular perfect (e.g., ⲕ-*z-y*)?
 2. Translate: ⲓ *Emar malkā*.
 3. Identify the root of ⲓ *ida* (he knew).
 4. Translate: ⲓ *Aytāw-hy* (bring him!). Why is the suffix *-hy* used instead of *-eh*?
 5. How would you say “I saw” (1 c.sg. of ⲕ-*z-y*)?
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SECTION 2: THE SEMITIC PREFIX CONJUGATION — OVERVIEW

We have learned that the Participle handles the *Present* (ongoing action) and the *Perfect* (Suffix Conjugation) handles the *Past* (completed action).

How does Syriac talk about the Future or expressing wishes/commands? It uses the **Imperfect Tense**, often called the “Prefix Conjugation.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Imperfect

In all Semitic languages, the Imperfect adds prefixes (*n-*, *t-*, ⲓ-, *y-*, etc.) to the root to indicate the person, while suffixes are used to indicate plural number.

- **Hebrew Qal Imperfect:** יִכְתֹּב (*yiktōb* — he will write), אֶכְתֹּב (*ektōb* — I will write).
- **Arabic Form I Imperfect:** يَكْتُبُ (*yaktubu* — he writes/will write), أَكْتُبُ (*aktubu* — I write).

- **Syriac Peal Imperfect:** ܢܝܬܘܒ (*nektūb* — he will write), ܐܝܬܘܒ (*'ektūb* — I will write).

Crucial Note on Syriac vs. Hebrew/Arabic: In Hebrew and Arabic, the 3rd person masculine prefix is **y-** (*ya-* or *yi-*). In standard Syriac, the 3rd person prefix shifted to **n-** (*ne-*).

SECTION 3: MORPHOLOGY AND SYNTAX OF THE IMPERFECT

1. Forming the Peal Imperfect

For a strong root like *k-t-b*, the base vocalization of the imperfect shifts to an *ū* (Waw) theme vowel between the second and third consonant: *-ktūb*. We then add the person-marking prefixes:

- *n-* (He / They m) → *n-ek-tūb* → **nektūb** (He will write).
- *t-* (You / She / They f) → **tektūb** (You will write / She will write).
- *'-* (I) → **'ektūb** (I will write).

2. Syntax: The Simple Future

By itself, the Imperfect functions as a simple future tense.

- *Nektūb Yūḥannan meltā.* (Yukhannan will write a word).
- *Tehze tammān malkā.* (You will see a king there).

3. Syntax: The Subjunctive / Purpose (**d-** + Imperfect)

Syriac uses the Imperfect heavily for purpose clauses, wishes, and commands. It accomplishes this by attaching the relative particle **d-** directly to the Imperfect verb. This corresponds to the Greek subjunctive with ἵνα (*hina*).

- *'Etā d-nehze* = He came **in order that he might see**.
- *'Āmer-nā d-tektūb* = I say **that you should write**.

SECTION 4: IMPERFECT TENSE PARADIGMS (PEAL, PAAEL, APHEL)

1. The Peal Imperfect Conjugation (Root **q-ṭ-l**)

In the Peal, the prefix has an *e* vowel in modern pronunciation (or *i* historically), and the theme vowel is usually *ū* (or *a* for gutturals).

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION	PREFIX	SUFFIX
3 m.sg.	ܢܥܬܘܠ	neqtūl	he will kill	n-	(none)
3 f.sg.	ܬܥܬܘܠ	teqtūl	she will kill	t-	(none)
2 m.sg.	ܬܥܬܘܠ	teqtūl	you (m) will kill	t-	(none)
2 f.sg.	ܬܥܬܝܢ	teqtlīn	you (f) will kill	t-	-īn
1 c.sg.	ܐܥܬܘܠ	'eqtūl	I will kill	' -	(none)
3 m.pl.	ܢܥܬܠܘܢ	neqtlūn	they (m) will kill	n-	-ūn
3 f.pl.	ܬܥܬܠܢ	neqtlān	they (f) will kill	n-	-ān
1 c.pl.	ܐܥܬܘܠ	neqtūl	we will kill	n-	(none)

Warning: The forms for “He will kill” (neqtūl) and “We will kill” (neqtūl) are identical in spelling and pronunciation! Context almost always makes it obvious.

2. The Pael Imperfect (Root **q-d-š** , to sanctify)

In the Pael the prefix has only a reduced vowel (*nqaddeš*), and the middle root letter is doubled.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION
3 m.sg.	ܢܩܕܕܝܫ	nqaddeš	he will sanctify
1 c.sg.	ܐܩܕܕܝܫ	'qaddeš	I will sanctify
3 m.pl.	ܢܩܕܕܝܫܘܢ	nqaddšūn	they will sanctify
1 c.pl.	ܐܩܕܕܝܫ	nqaddeš	we will sanctify

3. The Aphel Imperfect (Root **n-p-q** , Aphel = **'appeq** to bring out)

In the Aphel, the original 'a- prefix of the perfect drops out, and the imperfect prefix takes its place with an *a* vowel. The theme vowel is *e*.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION
3 m.sg.	ⲙⲁⲩ	nappeq	he will bring out
1 c.sg.	ⲙⲁⲩⲉ	'appeq	I will bring out
3 m.pl.	ⲙⲁⲩⲉⲙ	nappqūn	they will bring out

SECTION 5: THE SUBJUNCTIVE FLOW

Observe how the purpose clause flows in translation:

PRIMARY ACTION (PAST/PRESENT)	SUBJUNCTIVE CLAUSE (D- + IMPERFECT)	TRANSLATION
'Etā malkā (The king came)	d-neqṭūl l-eh (that he might kill him)	The king came in order to kill him.
Yūḥannan 'ābed nūhrā (Yukhannan makes light)	d-neḥzūn 'ammā (that the people might see)	Yukhannan makes light so that the people will see.

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (TIME, JUDGMENT & ROYAL COURT)

ROOT/NOUN	TRANSLITERATION	MEANING	RELATED CONCEPT
זכר / זמן	zban / zabnā	time	Temporal boundary
דמא	‘ damā	until	Used with <i>d-</i> (until that)
דין / דין	dīn / dīnā	judgment, law	Eschatological judgment
עלם / עולם	‘ ālam / ‘ ālmā	world, eternity	Often <i>l-</i> ‘ ālam (forever)
יום / יומא	yūm / yūmā	day	Heb. <i>yōm</i>
ש.מ.ד	sehed (Peal)	to testify/witness	Court setting
גזר	gzar (Peal)	to decree/cut	Royal authority
י.ה.ב	īteb (Peal)	to sit/enthronement	enthronement
ס.פ.ח	qṭal (Peal)	to kill	execution context
דחל / דחל	dḥal / deḥlā	fear/reverence	Root <i>d-ḥ-l</i> (to fear)
דן	dān (Peal, Hollow)	to judge	Active verb of <i>dīnā</i>

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 8

The Threat

Narrative note: The king uses the Subjunctive/Imperfect to express his threats and purpose concerning Yūkhannan's future.

Sentence 1

qām Yūḥannan qdām malkā d-dīnā. qām (stood) Yūḥannan (John) qdām (before) malkā (the-king) d-dīnā (of-judgment). → Yūkhannan stood before the king of judgment.

Sentence 2

w-īteb malkā w- 'emar l-ēh: w-īteb (and-sat) malkā (the-king) w- 'emar (and-said) l-ēh (to-him): → And the king sat and said to him:

Sentence 3

Sentence 4

Sentence 5

Sentence 6

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

1. נֶקְטֹּב (nektüb)
2. תֵּשֶׁבֶקֻּן (tešbqūn)
3. נֶבְדָּן (ne^ʿ bdān)
4. עֶזְזָה (ʿehzē — root h-z-y)

1. He will kill

2. We will kill
3. I will kill
4. They (m) will kill

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following future or subjunctive clauses.

1. Npaq malkā d-neḥzē l-Yūḥannan. (Remember ḥ-z-y acts weak).
2. Lā neqṭūl malkā l-gabrā ṭābā.
3. Tešbqūn l-baytkūn l- ʿ ālam.
4. Ktabt meltā d-yād ʿ īn ḥnan šrārā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following sentences into Syriac transliteration using the Imperfect.

1. I will write the decree (*gzar*) in the day of judgment.
2. The king decreed (*gzar*, perfect) that he might kill the men (*gabrē*).
3. If you (m.sg) do not leave heaven, you will see God.
4. They (m.pl) will come to the kingdom. (Hint: *nēthūn* from ʿ -t-y).

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. What does the king threaten to do to Yukhannan?
2. What is the condition the king sets?
3. What is Yukhannan's stated purpose for coming to the world?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. It becomes a long ʿ Alaph (ā). Example: ḥzā.
2. The king said.
3. y-d- ʿ (to know). I-Yodh.

4. Because the suffix is attaching to a vowel-ending word (the Aphel imperative *ʾaytāw*).
5. *ḥzēt* (I saw).

Exercise 1: Imperfect Identification

1. 3.m.sg or 1.c.pl (He will write / We will write)
2. 2.m.pl (You all will leave)
3. 3.f.pl (They [feminine] will do)
4. 1.c.sg (I will see)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. neqṭūl
2. neqṭūl
3. ʾeqṭūl
4. neqṭlūn

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. The king went out in order to see Yukhannan.
2. The king will not kill the good man.
3. You all will leave your house forever.
4. You wrote a word so that we might know the truth.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. ʾEktūb gzar b-yūm dīnā.
2. Gzar malkā d-neqṭūl l-gabrē.
3. ʾEn lā tešbūq šmayyā, teḥzē l-Alāhā.
4. Nēthūn l-malkūttā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. To kill him in the day of judgment.
2. If Yukhannan does not leave his land (“my land”).
3. To say/speak the word of God to the world.

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE PEAL IMPERFECT (Root q-t-l)

PERSON	SYRIAC	TRANSLIT
3 m.sg.	ܐܩܬܝܠ	neqtūl (he will kill)
3 f.sg.	ܐܩܬܝܠܝ	teqtūl (she will kill)
2 m.sg.	ܐܩܬܝܠܝܬ	teqtūl (you will kill)
1 c.sg.	ܐܩܬܝܠܝܬܝ	'eqtūl (I will kill)
3 m.pl.	ܐܩܬܝܠܝܬܝܬ	neqtlūn (they will k.)
1 c.pl.	ܐܩܬܝܠܝܬܝܬܝܬ	neqtūl (we will kill)

SYNTAX OF PURPOSE

Verb 1 (Any Tense) + **d-** + Verb 2 (Imperfect) = Purpose Clause 'Ezal (*He went*) *d-ne 'bed* (*in order to do*) *qyāmā* (*a covenant*).

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson's vocabulary to 30 terms.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING
קִרְיָה	qirīā	f	village
לִשָּׁן	leššānā	m	tongue, language
עֵצ	garmā	m	bone
סֶלֶסֶל	kēpā	f	stone, rock
דָּג	nūnā	m	fish
קִרְיָה	mdittā	f	city
שֶׁמֶשׁ	šemšā	m	sun
דֶּלֶת	tar ‘ ā	m	door, gate
שֶׁמֶן	mešhā	m	oil
סֵלָה	ḥaylā	m	power, army
אָזְנוֹ	’ednā	f	ear
עֵץ	qaysā	m	wood, tree
נָחַל	nahrā	m	river
סַבְרָה	sabrā	m	hope
סַהְרָה	sahrā	m	moon
רֶגֶל	reglā	f	foot
שָׁלוֹם	šlāmā	m	peace
מְקוֹם	’atrā	m	place, country
עֵד	sāhdā	m	witness, martyr
בָּשָׂר	besrā	m	flesh
חַסְדָּה	ṭaybüttā	f	grace
בָּקָר	tawrā	m	bull, ox
דֶּרֶךְ	’ūrḥā	f	way, road

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING
ܠܬܡܐ	hayklā	m	temple, palace
ܥܝܢܐ	‘aynā	f	eye
ܡܘܬܐ	pūmā	m	mouth
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	pāraḥtā	f	bird
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	ḥadūtā	f	joy
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	ḥekmtā	f	wisdom
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	ḥayyūtā	f	animal, beast
ܦܝܪܐ	pīrā	m	fruit
ܠܒܐ	kalbā	m	dog
ܥܪܒܐ	‘erbā	m	sheep
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	ṭūrā	m	mountain
ܫܘܩܐ	šūqā	m	street, market
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	‘āqtā	f	distress, anguish
ܢܘܪܐ	nūrā	f	fire
ܪܚܡܐ	raḥmē	m.pl	mercy
ܡܝܚܪܐ	meḥartā	f	tomorrow
ܙܢܐ	zannā	m	time, era
ܪܝܫܐ	rešā	m	head (leadership)
ܝܢ	‘in	conj	if
ܥܝܠܐ	‘ōlyā	adv	perhaps
ܬܝܪܝܬܐ	p ‘āltā	f	trust, confidence
ܕܗܠܐ	deḥlā	m	fear
ܝܕܥܐ	yed ‘ā	m	knowledge